

Eating disorders

Eating disorders are a range of conditions characterized by abnormal, unhealthy, or even dangerous eating habits. They affect people regardless of their gender, race, or background.

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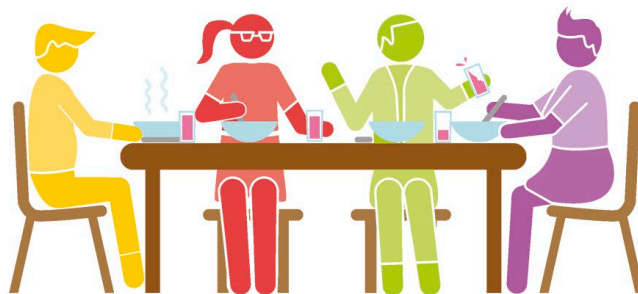
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Relationships with eating

Eating enables people to stay physically and mentally well, and mealtimes allow for bonding and socializing with loved ones. But when a person's relationship with food dominates their thinking, or becomes unhealthy or harmful, it's known as an eating disorder.

Eating disorders occur when a person's relationship with food becomes the source of internal pressure or a means of exerting control over their situation. They can develop for many reasons, including feeling pressure to look a certain way, or experiencing a stressful life event.



△ Food and socializing

Food is a big part of the daily routine, and mealtimes can be a struggle for someone with an eating disorder.

Types of eating disorder

The characteristics of an individual's eating disorder can change over time and people can have more than one at once. These are the most commonly recognized disorders.

Anorexia Nervosa

This disorder involves a distorted perception of being overweight, leading to eating very little, missing meals, or regular fasting.

Other characteristics include being very underweight, obsessive weighing and calorie counting, over-exercising, and using laxatives.

Complications include dizziness and fainting, dry skin, fatigue, hair loss, impaired memory, infertility, irregular menstruation, muscle loss, risk of kidney and liver damage, and weak bones.

Bulimia Nervosa

This condition is a cycle of overeating (known as bingeing) to cope with stress or emotional anxiety, followed by vomiting in order to purge the body of food and to avoid weight gain.

Other characteristics include fasting or over-exercising after bingeing, anxiety, and guilt caused by failing to meet impossible dietary restrictions.

Complications include dehydration, irregular menstruation, mineral deficiency, stomach ulcers, swollen saliva glands, risk of bowel and heart problems, and tooth decay.

Binge Eating Disorder

This disorder consists of repeated episodes of compulsive binge eating in private, to cope with negative feelings.

Other characteristics include anxiety and depression; feelings of guilt, shame, or loss of control; and buying certain foods in advance before a bingeing session.

Complications include being overweight or obese, diabetes, high cholesterol, osteoarthritis, painful or swollen joints, risk of heart problems, and bowel or breast cancer.